

SUMMIT TUITION ASSESSMENT

POEM COMPREHENSION — MULTIPLE CHOICE TECHNIQUE*4 Poems, All Questions Multiple Choice — Apply S.N.I.P.E.R. To Every One***Instructions to candidates**

- This entire paper is multiple choice — there is no written answer needed anywhere.
- For every question, use the S.N.I.P.E.R. method from your notes: Skim all options, Negate wrong ones, Identify half-right traps, Pick the closest to the text, Evidence-check, Re-read the question.
- Circle your chosen letter (A, B, C or D) — do not just underline it.
- At least one option in every question is a deliberate "half-right" trap — it uses a real word or idea from the poem but twists its meaning. Do not pick an option just because you recognise a word from the poem.

Candidate name _____

Date _____

Time started / finished _____

POEM 1: THE LIGHTHOUSE KEEPER'S WATCH

Each night I climb the spiral stair alone,
past rusted rails that hum beneath my hand,
to light the lamp that warns the restless sea
away from rocks it cannot understand.

The ships pass by like sentences half-read,
their lanterns blinking messages I miss.
I wonder if their sailors ever guess
a single, watching stranger governs this.

They call me keeper, as though I keep more
than glass and oil and one relentless flame.
Perhaps I keep the coastline's oldest fear:
that darkness, left alone, forgets its name.

Tonight the fog rolls in and swallows sound.
I light the lamp. I do not light for praise.
Somewhere, a captain trusts a light he's never seen
to carry him through unfamiliar days.

1. What does the phrase "ships pass by like sentences half-read" mainly suggest?

[1]

- A. The keeper cannot read very well.
- B. The ships are moving too quickly to be seen properly.
- C. The keeper only ever glimpses a small, incomplete part of each ship's story.
- D. The sentences on the ships' signal flags are difficult to translate.

2. In the third stanza, what does the keeper suggest he truly "keeps"?

[1]

- A. The lighthouse building itself, which needs regular repair.
- B. A sense of order and safety that stops fear from taking hold.
- C. A private diary of every ship that has ever passed.
- D. The oil and glass that are needed to light the lamp each night.

3. What tone best describes the final stanza?

[1]

- A. Bitter and resentful about being unnoticed.
- B. Anxious that the light might fail.
- C. Quietly purposeful, content with unseen duty.
- D. Confused about why the fog has arrived.

4. Why does the poet repeat the word "light" as both a noun and a verb in the final stanza ("light the lamp", "a light he's never seen")?

[1]

- A. To show the keeper is forgetful and repeats his tasks.
- B. To emphasise that the keeper's simple daily action has an effect far beyond what he can see.
- C. Because the poet could not think of another word to use.
- D. To create a rhyme with the word "sight".

5. Which statement about the captain in the final stanza is best supported by the poem?

[1]

- A. The captain has met the lighthouse keeper before.
- B. The captain relies on something and someone he will never actually see.
- C. The captain is lost and does not know where the lighthouse is.
- D. The captain doubts the lighthouse keeper's ability to do his job.

6. What is the poem mainly about?

[1]

- A. The dangers of working at sea during fog.
- B. A keeper's quiet, unseen dedication to a duty that protects strangers.
- C. A keeper who wishes he had chosen a different job.
- D. The history and construction of lighthouses.

POEM 2: AUTUMN'S RETREAT

The trees undress in slow, unhurried gold,
each leaf a letter dropped without a name.
The garden that once burned with summer's noise
grows quiet, as though listening for rain.

I used to think that autumn meant an end —
a dying, dressed in colours far too bright.
But now I see it differently: a pause,
the earth undressing gently for the night.

The birds that stayed all summer start to leave,
their formations stitched across the sky.
Not fleeing danger — simply moving on,
the way that all things change, and wonder why.

So let the garden fold its colours in.
Let frost arrive, and quiet, and the cold.
I no longer fear the turning of the year —
I've learned that endings can be edged in gold.

1. What does the word "undress" suggest about the trees in the first line?

[1]

- A. The trees are being damaged by strong wind.
- B. The trees are gradually, naturally shedding their leaves, almost like removing clothing.
- C. The trees are ashamed of how they look in autumn.
- D. The trees are being deliberately stripped by gardeners.

2. How does the speaker's attitude towards autumn change between the first and second stanzas?

[1]

- A. It changes from thinking autumn is an ending to seeing it as a pause or transition.
- B. It changes from loving autumn to fearing it.
- C. It stays exactly the same throughout the poem.
- D. It changes from calm to panicked as winter approaches.

3. Why does the poet compare the birds' departure to "the way that all things change" rather than describing it as dangerous or sad?

[1]

- A. To suggest the birds are actually confused about where to go.
- B. To connect the birds' natural movement to the poem's wider theme of accepting change calmly.
- C. Because the poet does not know why birds migrate.
- D. To criticise the birds for leaving too early in the year.

4. What is the effect of ending the poem with the phrase "endings can be edged in gold"?

[1]

- A. It suggests that even difficult changes or endings can have something beautiful or valuable about them.
- B. It suggests that gold is the speaker's favourite colour.
- C. It implies the speaker has found actual gold in the garden.
- D. It shows the speaker is still afraid of autumn, despite saying otherwise.

5. Which best describes the overall structure of the poem's argument?

[1]

- A. It stays negative about autumn from beginning to end.
- B. It moves from an old, fearful view of autumn to a new, more peaceful understanding of it.
- C. It describes four completely unconnected scenes with no shared idea.
- D. It argues that summer is better than every other season.

6. What is the poem mainly suggesting?

[1]

- A. That autumn is the most dangerous season for wildlife.
- B. That change and endings, if viewed differently, can be accepted calmly rather than feared.
- C. That gardens require a lot of maintenance in autumn.
- D. That birds are wiser than people about the changing seasons.

POEM 3: THE SILENT PIANO

It stands beside the window, lid shut tight,
its keys unpressed since Grandad's final spring.
Dust settles soft as unplayed melodies
on wood that used to hum with everything.

Mum says we ought to sell it — "It's just space,
a thing that gathers silence, nothing more."
But I have seen her pause beside its frame
and rest her hand there, longer than before.

I do not play. I never learned the notes.
But sometimes, when the house feels far too still,
I lift the lid and press one single key —
not for the tune, but just to prove I will.

One note can hold a hundred silent years.
One note can say the things we've left unsaid.
The piano waits, in no great hurry now,
for someone brave enough to wake the dead.

1. What does "Dust settles soft as unplayed melodies" suggest about the piano?

[1]

- A. The piano is broken and can no longer make any sound.
- B. The silence and stillness of the piano has become its own kind of sad, quiet music.
- C. The house is generally very dusty and needs cleaning.
- D. Grandad used to play very quiet, gentle music.

2. What does Mum's action of resting her hand on the piano "longer than before" suggest, despite her words?

[1]

- A. She is checking the piano for damage before selling it.
- B. She genuinely does not care about the piano at all.
- C. She feels a deeper emotional attachment to the piano than her practical words admit.
- D. She is trying to remember how to play a specific song.

3. Why does the speaker press "one single key... not for the tune, but just to prove I will"?

[1]

- A. The speaker is testing whether the piano still works.
- B. The speaker wants to annoy Mum by making noise.
- C. The small act is a way of connecting to Grandad's memory and resisting total silence, even without musical skill.
- D. The speaker is bored and has nothing else to do.

4. What is the effect of the phrase "wake the dead" in the final line?

[1]

- A. It literally suggests the piano is haunted.
- B. It suggests playing the piano again could bring Grandad's memory vividly back to life for the family.
- C. It shows the speaker is frightened of the piano.
- D. It is simply a common phrase with no particular meaning here.

5. Why might the poet have chosen to end the poem on the word "dead" rather than a softer word like "silence"?

[1]

- A. To create a shocking, blunt final image that confronts the reader with the real grief underneath the poem's quiet tone.
- B. Because "dead" was the only word that rhymed.
- C. To suggest the piano itself is now beyond repair.
- D. Because the poem is actually about a funeral, not a piano.

6. What is the poem mainly about?

[1]

- A. A family's argument over whether to sell an old piano.
- B. How grief and memory can be held inside an ordinary object, and how small acts can keep a memory alive.
- C. A guide to learning the piano as an adult.
- D. The history of piano-making.

POEM 4: RACE AGAINST RAIN

The starting gun cracks sharper than the sky,
and forty trainers strike the track as one.
The clouds above have made their own quiet bet
on who will lose before the race is won.

My lungs burn first — a fire I've trained to hold,
each breath a rhythm counted, sharp and small.
Somewhere ahead, a girl in emerald green
has never, not once this season, lost at all.

The rain arrives exactly when I need
one thing, just one, to fight for other than the time.
It stings my face like something almost proud
of making every runner's effort climb.

I do not catch the girl in emerald green.
I finish second, soaked, and strangely light.
Some races aren't for winning after all —
some races teach you how to lose it right.

1. What does the phrase "the clouds above have made their own quiet bet" suggest? [1]
- A. The weather is personified as an indifferent, almost mischievous force watching the race unfold.
 - B. The runners have actually placed bets on the outcome of the race.
 - C. The race has been cancelled due to weather.
 - D. The clouds are literally speaking to the runners.
2. What does the detail about the girl in emerald green who has "never, not once this season, lost at all" mainly do? [1]
- A. It shows the speaker dislikes the girl in green personally.
 - B. It establishes the scale of the challenge the speaker is facing, raising the stakes of the race.
 - C. It suggests the girl in green cheated to win her previous races.
 - D. It proves the speaker has never trained properly before this race.
3. Why does the rain "sting" the speaker's face "like something almost proud"? [1]
- A. The rain is personified as taking satisfaction in making the race harder for everyone, adding to the challenge.
 - B. The speaker is allergic to rain.
 - C. The rain is literally a person watching the race.
 - D. The speaker is embarrassed about crying during the race.
4. What does the speaker mean by finishing "soaked, and strangely light"? [1]
- A. The speaker has lost weight from the physical effort of running.
 - B. The speaker feels a surprising sense of relief or peace despite not winning, rather than the disappointment they expected.
 - C. The rain has made the speaker's clothes lighter in colour.
 - D. The speaker is confused about the result of the race.
5. What is the effect of the final line, "some races teach you how to lose it right"? [1]
- A. It suggests losing is always a purely negative experience.
 - B. It reframes the idea of losing as something that can still be valuable or dignified, summing up the poem's theme.
 - C. It implies the race result was unfair.
 - D. It suggests the speaker plans to quit running altogether.

6. What is the poem mainly about?

[1]

- A. The rules and history of competitive running.
- B. Learning to find dignity and peace in effort and defeat, not only in winning.
- C. A rivalry that ends in an argument between two runners.
- D. The dangers of running in bad weather.

Tutor Answer Key

Poem 1 — The Lighthouse Keeper's Watch: 1-C, 2-B, 3-C, 4-B, 5-B, 6-B

Poem 2 — Autumn's Retreat: 1-B, 2-A, 3-B, 4-A, 5-B, 6-B

Poem 3 — The Silent Piano: 1-B, 2-C, 3-C, 4-B, 5-A, 6-B

Poem 4 — Race Against Rain: 1-A, 2-B, 3-A, 4-B, 5-B, 6-B

Every question has one "half-right" trap option that reuses a real word/idea from the poem but twists its meaning — if Lupin picks a wrong answer, ask him to point to the exact word in the poem that tricked him, then re-apply S.N.I.P.E.R. out loud.